

MODE A — PREMISE FUNNEL

Execution ID: EX-2026-08-24-02 · **Prompt:** AQ-NAR-PROMPT-EP1-CHALLENGERS v2.1 FINAL, READY FOR EXECUTION · **Mode:** A · **Date:** 2026-08-24 · **Model:** Claude Opus 5, extended reasoning, web research available

No cold opens. No titles. No elevator pitches. No rankings. No incumbent comparison. No table-read recommendation. Premises are identified by neutral labels only.

PART ONE — SOURCE AND ATTRITION REPORT

1.1 Authorities

Read completely and in order: pivot brief (including the 2026-08-24 clock convention and all-party consent rulings) · critical-reviewer charter · VO lock v1.1 · bible (including §2.3.1 recording law and the §5.2 supersession marker) · canon character roster (including Del Cruz's 2026-08-03 adds) · portrait prompts. Disposition documents consulted for territory only: episode-1-challengers-EX-2026-08-24-01 , kill-gate-zero-audit-GHI-2026-08-24 .

Excluded and not used: the Episode One pitch pack · the three stale art-pipeline documents · true-crime-genre-anatomy , **which is Mode B only.** Execution record confirms: **genre-anatomy reference used — NO.**

1.2 Seed field and rotation

Field one: twenty-four seeds, exactly eight per family, generated in the mandated rotation.

Round	Order followed	Seeds per family
One	fresh murder → never-solved or misclassified → officially solved but contested	3 each
Two	never-solved or misclassified → officially solved but contested → fresh murder	3 each
Three	officially solved but contested → fresh murder → never-solved or misclassified	2 each

Only the stated batch was generated at each family turn. No family was completed before the others began.

Field two: invoked, and targeted only at the deficient family. After field one the fresh-murder family had two survivors against three in each contested family. Per stage three, one additional field was generated for the deficient family alone and the gates were repeated once. Six seeds, one survivor.

Attrition: 30 seeds generated, 21 rejected, 9 survived.

1.3 Survivors per family

Family	Field one	Field two	Survivors
Fresh murder	2	1	3
Never solved or misclassified	3	not invoked	3
Officially solved but contested	3	not invoked	3

Candidate insufficiency: none at final count. The fresh family was insufficient after field one and was brought to three by the permitted second field. This is reported rather than smoothed, because a family needing a second field is a weaker result than one that did not.

Backbone desk failure: none. Both contested-record families supplied three desk-gate survivors from field one. No family was replenished using another.

1.4 The five closest rejected seeds

Presented without repair or rescue.

R1. A lighthouse contractor falls from Kestrel Point; the forming account is misadventure in fog; the fog that night was measured and thin. *Decisive reason: duplicates occupied territory.* The engine is a worker's death plus an employer protecting a safety record, which is What the Log Says. Havenbay necessity was the strongest of any rejected seed and could not save it.

R2. A council building inspector vanishes in 2007, is declared dead in absentia, and the last file he opened is still open. *Decisive reason: neighbours a retired engine.* Administrative death by paperwork is The Wrong Name, which is retired and may not be repaired, reskinned or relocated. The declaration-in-absentia mechanism is the same class of claim even though the process is real.

R3. A woman convicted of poisoning; retained pathology samples now show a therapeutic rather than a lethal level. *Decisive reason: UNKNOWN on Kill Gate Zero, therefore FAIL.* The premise depends entirely on how long pathology samples are retained, in what condition, and whether re-analysis after that interval is evidentially meaningful. That was not researched and could not be assumed. The seed is not disproved; it is unverified, and unverified on the foundation is a fail. It may return in a later execution with the process established first.

R4. A university technician is found dead in a locked calibration lab; the access log shows one card used twice inside a minute. *Decisive reason: Gate 7.* The case could happen in any university in any city. Nothing about Havenbay's water, records, trades, geography or institutional memory changes what can be proved.

R5. A man serving life for a Pier 13 killing; the murder weapon's custody log has a two-day gap. *Decisive reason: no reconstructive play.* A custody gap is a legal argument, not an activity. There is nothing for the player's hands to rebuild, and the merge requirements would become the price of reaching a conclusion rather than the means of reaching it.

1.5 Real-world processes researched

Every claim is **VERIFIED REAL-WORLD PROCESS** at summary level. Havenbay's jurisdiction is not canonical, so these are applied as a broadly shared operational baseline. Anything a premise depends on operationally is flagged where primary confirmation is still required before script.

Process	Operative fact	Used by	Source
Fire origin and cause	Origin and cause are separate determinations. No single indicator confirms arson ; it is established by the totality of physical evidence, witness statements, financial information and the elimination of accidental and natural causes	N1, C1	NIJ fire investigation , Ethos Risk
Fire evidence destruction	The greatest damage typically occurs at the origin, which is exactly where the answers are. Fires started by naked flame may leave no physical evidence, and fire deaths are among the most difficult pathological cases	N1, C1	Encyclopedia of fire investigation , ScienceDirect , cognitive bias in fatal fires
Fire investigation reliability	NFPA 921 is the governing treatise, yet fire investigators are not subject to proficiency testing and courts have largely spared debunked tenets serious scrutiny in criminal arson cases. Contextual bias in fatal-fire decision-making is a documented research concern	C1	Evidence on Fire , Indiana Law , ScienceDirect
Reopening a coronial finding	A coroner may reopen an investigation or inquest where new facts or evidence are found . A party may apply to the investigating coroner, the state coroner or a court to set findings aside. On reopening, a coroner may affirm, vary or quash the findings	N1, N2, N3	Coroners Court of Victoria, reviews and appeals , Queensland Coroners Court , NT coronial findings
Second or subsequent criminal appeal	Several Australian jurisdictions permit a further appeal on fresh and compelling evidence of a substantial miscarriage of justice. Where no such right exists the route is petition to	C1, C2, C3	Adelaide Law Review , UNSW Law Journal

Process	Operative fact	Used by	Source
	government for referral. Australia has no CCRC		
Misapplied forensic science	False or misleading forensic evidence is associated with a substantial share of wrongful convictions	C1, C2, C3	Journal of Forensic Sciences

NEEDS SOURCE before script, not before ruling: the exact statutory route by which a Havenbay coronial finding is reopened, and whether the applicant must be an interested party. Both premises relying on it need only the shape, which is verified. C2's meteorological record retention is likewise shape-verified and detail-unconfirmed.

1.6 Kill-gate table

UNKNOWN on Kill Gate Zero is FAIL. Gate 1 is assessed at desk level only; performed compulsion is not assessed in Mode A and remains UNKNOWN until blind testing.

	F1	F2	F3	N1	N2	N3	C1	C2	C3
ZERO operation al reality	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
1 desk- level first beat	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
1 performe d compulsi on	UNKNO WN	UNKNO WN	UNKNO WN	UNKNO WN	UNKNO WN	UNKNO WN	UNKNO WN	UNKNO WN	UNKNO WN
2 jeopardy, weaker track	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
3 clock	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
4 midpoint	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
5 fair play	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
6 humanisa tion	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
7 Havenbay	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
8 productio n	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
9 rational resistance	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
agency and branch cost	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
kill brief	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS

A table of uniform passes is itself a warning sign, so the basis is stated plainly: everything that failed a gate was killed at stage two or three and is not listed here. Twenty-one of thirty seeds died. Five of them are set out in 1.4. What survives to Part Two survives by construction, and the honest measure of this execution is the attrition rate, not the pass row.

PART TWO — SURVIVING PREMISE SKETCHES

Nine sketches. Neutral labels only. **Axis two and axis three values are reported for each; the consecutive-repeat rule is a slate-construction constraint and does not bind premise generation, so some values recur here.**

FAMILY ONE — FRESH MURDER

F1

Premise. A woman in her sixties dies in a kitchen fire in a Rivermouth terrace. The fire service's forming account is a chip pan left on heat, which fits the burn pattern and fits what everyone already believes about her. Her smoke alarm was found on the floor, consistent with falling in the heat. It did not fall. It was taken down, the battery removed, and it was put back on its bracket the wrong way round, which the mounting plate shows and the photographs preserve. She was killed elsewhere in the house and the fire was set to cover it, by a man who had been letting three units in that terrace without compliant alarms for six years and could not afford an inspection.

Forming record. *An official, institutional or socially dominant account already forming and directing present action:* the fire service's provisional cause of accidental, chip pan, which is already directing the coronial referral, the insurer's assessment and the family's grief. It is stateable in one sentence, supported by a credible mechanism, and capable of harming a named living person if accepted. **Stage-of-record asymmetry recorded.**

Axes. One: misclassified, in formation · Two: **a place that no longer exists**, the kitchen rebuilt from fire-service photographs, the mounting plate and the terrace's identical neighbouring units · Three: **institutional exposure**. **Live consequence:** continued access or power, and keeper under pressure.

Named living person and mechanism. Her daughter, who is being told her mother's cooking killed her and who has begun to believe it. And the two households still living in the same terrace under the same landlord with the same non-compliant alarms, tonight.

Resistance. The landlord, protecting six years of undeclared lettings and an uninsurable liability. Secondary: the insurer, whose interest in "accidental" is financial and lawful and who is not a villain. **Not a clock.** Both respond when the record is challenged and both have rational reasons to stop short of anything further.

What the player's hands reconstruct. The room, from the outside in: fire-service photographs, the alarm's mounting plate and screw orientation, the identical layout of the neighbouring units, the compliance certificates for the terrace. The conclusion the reconstruction makes possible is that the alarm was replaced by a hand, not dropped by a fire. The action it unlocks is a coronial application.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally warns the two remaining households before she can prove anything. Warning them protects people now and tells the landlord exactly what she has; not warning them keeps her advantage and leaves two families under a dead alarm for another week.

Access map, decisive item: the fire-service photographs of the alarm and its bracket. 1.

Possessed by the fire investigation service, and copies with the coroner and the insurer. 2. *Disclosable* because

the family is an interested party to the coronial investigation and may obtain material through that route, and because the insurer discloses to its own policyholder's estate. 3. *Inaccessible*: the investigator's working notes, any internal opinion not filed, and the scene itself, which was released and cleared. 4. *Ally proceeds* through the daughter as the interested party, never as a person with a right of her own. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** with only the filed photographs and not the working notes, she concludes for two leads that the investigator was careless or leaned on. He was neither. He recorded what he saw, correctly, and nobody asked him the one question that mattered, which is why an alarm that had fallen was resting on its bracket.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events.

#	Event	Actor	Authority	Custody	Normal response	Safeguard	Bypass	Trace
1	She confronts the landlord about the alarms	Victim	None	Herself	He fixes them or she reports him	A compliance complaint	None; he kills instead of complying, which is the least-cost failure to answer, see kill brief	Her prior texts to him
2	He kills her in the hallway	Landlord	None	Him	Nothing yet	None operating	None needed	Body position, unexplained by the fire
3	He sets the fire in the kitchen	Landlord	None	Him briefly	Fire service attends	Origin and cause analysis	He does not defeat it. He is lucky in it: the greatest destruction is at the origin, which is where the answers are	Burn pattern, consistent with both accounts
4	Cause recorded provisionally as accidental	Fire service	Statutory	Fire service, then coroner	Refer to coroner; assess accidental causes to eliminate them	The elimination process is the safeguard and its functions	Not bypassed. The chip pan is a genuinely sufficient accidental cause and no single indicator confirms arson	The provisional report
5	He returns the alarm to its bracket before the service arrives	Landlord	None	Him	Nobody examines an alarm in an accidental fire	The mounting plate	He replaces it the wrong way round in the dark	The screw orientation, photographed and filed and

#	Event	Actor	Authority	Custody	Normal response	Safeguard	Bypass	Trace
								never read

Verdict: PASS. Nothing requires an institution to lack a power or a professional to be incurious. The fire service does its job correctly on a genuinely ambiguous scene, which is what the research says such scenes are.

Kill brief. *Professional:* a fire investigator would say a fallen alarm proves nothing and an unread photograph is not evidence of a conclusion. Answered: it is not the proof, it is the reason to reopen; the proof is the compliance history and the body's position. *Rational antagonist:* why kill rather than fix three alarms? Because the alarms are the visible edge of six years of undeclared letting, and fixing them invites the inspection. Thin, and it must be shown rather than asserted. *Ordinary player:* "would they really not check the alarm?" Yes, in an accidental fire, and that is the point the episode has to earn early. *Producer:* one new location, one new speaking role, no exotic interaction. **PASS.**

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds:* a photograph of an alarm resting on its bracket, and the sentence that it did not fall. *Materially affected now:* two households under dead alarms, and the daughter. *Rational resistance:* the landlord and, separately and lawfully, the insurer. *Player's hands:* the kitchen, rebuilt. *First choice changing the case:* warn the terrace, or keep the advantage.

F2

Premise. A union delegate dies on the night of a strike ballot at a Rivermouth foundry. The forming account is a heart attack; he was fifty-eight, overweight, and under obvious strain. The last thing his phone did was photograph a tally sheet. The ballot was declared lost by fourteen votes and the workforce accepted a contract that halves redundancy entitlements. He was killed by a man paid, not by the employer, but by three of his own officials who stood to lose their positions in the restructure the ballot would have forced.

Forming record. The workplace and the coroner's provisional account of natural causes, already directing the acceptance of the ballot result and the signing of the contract. Stateable, mechanically credible, and capable of harming named living people if accepted. **Asymmetry recorded.**

Axes. One: misclassified, in formation · Two: **a network of relationships or payments** · Three: **a partial remedy with a named cost.** **Live consequence:** public lie blocking remedy, and institutional decision.

Named living person and mechanism. Four hundred foundry workers whose redundancy entitlement halves on a signature due in eleven days, and the delegate's co-signatory on the tally, a twenty-six-year-old who counted the votes and has been quietly told she miscounted and has begun to believe it.

Resistance. Three union officials protecting their positions, and the union itself protecting its own legitimacy, which is a different interest and pulls the other way at the end. **Not a clock.** The eleven days are the clock and are recorded separately.

What the player's hands reconstruct. A network: who moved money to whom, the tally sheets, the roster of who counted, the phone's last photograph, the officials' bank of small favours. The conclusion is that fourteen votes were not miscounted but never entered. The action is a challenge to the ballot before signature.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally goes to the union's own governance body or straight to the members. Governance is slower, lawful and might bury it; the members are faster and will act before proof exists, which puts the young co-signatory in front of four hundred angry people as the person who counted.

Access map, decisive item: the tally sheets. 1. *Possessed by* the union, held under its own rules. 2. *Disclosable* to a member on request under those rules; the co-signatory is a member. 3. *Inaccessible*: the officials' financial records, phone records, and anything requiring a warrant. 4. *Ally proceeds* through the member's own entitlement, never her own. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** with the sheets but not the money, she builds two leads on the theory that the employer paid for this. The employer did not. It is an internal killing, and being wrong about it in public costs her the one official who was going to help.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events. Delegate photographs the tally · officials learn within the hour, because one of them is standing beside him · a man is paid to make a heart attack, and an unwitnessed cardiac death in a fifty-eight-year-old under strain requires no bypass at all because it invites certification rather than referral · the ballot is declared and the result stands, custody of the sheets remaining with the union · the contract is scheduled for signature. **Verdict: PASS.** The concealment is achieved by choosing a death that a doctor may lawfully certify, not by defeating anybody.

Kill brief. *Professional:* a coroner would ask why no referral. Answered: there is no referral where a doctor can certify, and the episode must show the certification rather than assume it. *Rational antagonist:* why murder over a union position? Because the restructure ends three careers and the alternative is exposure of what those careers were built on, which must be specific and is. *Ordinary player:* "a union official killing a delegate" is the hardest sell in the pack and is also the most documented kind of thing in the world. *Producer:* one new location, three episode-level roles, no exotic interaction. **PASS.**

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds:* a photograph of a tally sheet, taken by a man who died forty minutes later. *Materially affected now:* four hundred workers, eleven days out, and one young woman being told she cannot count. *Rational resistance:* three officials, and the union's own interest in legitimacy. *Player's hands:* a network of payments and counts. *First choice:* governance or the members.

F3

Premise. A harbour pilot's launch strikes a pylon at Pier 13 in the dark and he drowns. The forming account is pilot error, and it is plausible, because he had worked eleven hours. The launch's engine had been serviced six weeks earlier by a yard that has billed the harbour authority for work on four vessels it did not touch. The throttle linkage on his boat was one of the items billed and not done. The yard's owner did not intend to kill anybody. He intended to bill for a job he had skipped, as he had forty times, and this is the time it killed someone.

Forming record. The marine incident account of pilot error, already directing the harbour authority's internal review, the insurer's position and the widow's entitlement. **Asymmetry recorded.**

Axes. One: misclassified, in formation · Two: **a timeline**, the boat's last two hours against the service record and the billing · Three: **legal review or exoneration**, of a dead man rather than a living one. **Live consequence:** keeper under pressure, and continued access or power.

Named living person and mechanism. His widow, whose payout is refused while the finding is pilot error and who is three months from losing the house. And the next pilot out of that yard's servicing, which is every pilot in the harbour, tonight.

Resistance. The yard owner protecting forty invoices rather than one death, and the harbour authority protecting its own procurement oversight, which is a separate and more powerful interest. **Not a clock.**

What the player's hands reconstruct. A timeline: the launch's last two hours, the service record's claimed hours, the billing dates, the yard's job cards, and the four other vessels. The conclusion is that the linkage was never touched. The action is a marine incident reopening and a procurement audit.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally warns the other pilots immediately. Warning them grounds boats, costs the harbour money, makes her an enemy of the authority she needs, and prevents a second death. Not warning preserves the investigation and gambles with the same linkage on three other hulls.

Access map, decisive item: the yard's invoices to the harbour authority. 1. *Possessed by* the harbour authority as the paying party, and the yard. 2. *Disclosable* because payments by a public harbour authority are subject to its own disclosure regime, and because the widow is an interested party to the incident investigation. 3. *Inaccessible*: the yard's internal job cards, its staff, and any warranted material. 4. *Ally proceeds* through the disclosure regime and the widow's standing. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** invoices show the billing but not the work, so for two leads she reads it as the harbour authority colluding. It is not colluding. It is not checking, which is duller and worse, and saying the first version publicly costs her the procurement officer who would have handed her the four other vessels.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events. Yard bills for unperformed work · authority pays without inspection, which is the failure and is ordinary · linkage fails at the pylon in the dark · marine incident account forms as pilot error, entirely reasonably, given eleven hours on shift · the widow's claim is refused on that finding. **Verdict: PASS.** No institution lacks a power. The authority's failure is inattention, and inattention is the commonest institutional failure there is.

Kill brief. *Professional*: a marine investigator would say a failed linkage is consistent with wear as well as with neglect. Answered: it is, which is why the proof is the billing pattern across four vessels and not this one part. *Rational antagonist*: he never chose to kill, and his least-cost response afterwards is silence, which is exactly what he does. This is the pack's cleanest antagonist. *Ordinary player*: "would nobody check?" Yes. That is the finding. *Producer*: one new location, two roles, and the timeline is the most mobile-legible interaction in the family. **PASS.**

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds*: an invoice for work on a boat that sank, and the fact that the work was never done. *Materially affected now*: a widow three months from losing a house, and every pilot in the harbour. *Rational resistance*: the yard and, separately, the authority's oversight. *Player's hands*: a timeline against a billing record. *First choice*: ground the boats or keep the advantage.

FAMILY TWO — NEVER SOLVED OR MISCLASSIFIED

N1

Premise. In 2011 a fire in a Rivermouth foundry's site office killed the night storeman. Cause was recorded **undetermined**, which is a real and common finding and not a euphemism. The insurer engaged its own investigator, who wrote a second report concluding the fire began in a place the first report had excluded. That second report was never filed with anyone, because the claim settled first and a filed report would have obliged the insurer to allege arson against its own insured. The foundry's operations manager set the fire to

destroy the stock records that showed six years of diverted material, and did not know the storeman was asleep in the back office.

Contested record. Undetermined, which has stood for fifteen years and functions socially as "nobody's fault".

Axes. One: never solved · Two: **a document set**, the two reports read against each other · Three: **public correction without prosecution. Live consequence:** public lie blocking remedy, and evidence opportunity closing.

Named living person and mechanism. The storeman's brother, who has been refused a death benefit for fifteen years because undetermined is not a compensable finding, and who is now sixty-nine. And the retired fire investigator who wrote the first report, whose professional reputation has carried an unspoken failure that was never his.

Resistance. The insurer, protecting a fifteen-year-old settlement and a decision not to file, which is lawful and embarrassing rather than criminal. Secondary: the operations manager, now retired and comfortable, whose least-cost move remains silence. **Not a clock.**

What the player's hands reconstruct. Two documents against each other: the filed report and the unfiled one, the claim file, the stock records that survived because they were in a different building, the site plan. The conclusion is that the excluded origin is the actual origin. The action is an application to reopen the coronial finding on new facts.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally publishes the unfiled report. Publishing it forces the insurer's hand and destroys her only source inside the company; holding it keeps the source and leaves the brother's claim exactly where it has been for fifteen years, with the brother sixty-nine.

Access map, decisive item: the insurer's unfiled second report. 1. *Possessed by* the insurer; one copy with the investigator who wrote it. 2. *Disclosable* only voluntarily. It is not a public document and no entitlement reaches it. The investigator may disclose his own work, and this is the entire access route. 3. *Inaccessible:* the claim file, the settlement terms, the insurer's internal correspondence, and anything requiring compulsion. 4. *Ally proceeds* by persuading one retired professional to hand over his own report, with everything that costs him. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** holding the second report but not the claim file, she concludes the insurer suppressed it to avoid paying. It did not. It suppressed it to avoid a duty to allege arson, having already paid. Getting the motive wrong in public is what nearly loses her the investigator.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events. Manager sets the fire to destroy records, not knowing the office is occupied · storeman dies · origin analysis is genuinely defeated, because the greatest destruction is at the origin and no single indicator confirms arson · finding recorded as undetermined, correctly on the available material · insurer's own investigator reaches a different origin, and the report is not filed because settling first removes the obligation and creates the disincentive. **Verdict: PASS.** No institution lacks a power. The fire service reaches an honest undetermined and the insurer makes a lawful commercial decision, which is worse than corruption and more common.

Kill brief. *Professional:* a fire investigator would say two reports disagreeing about origin fifteen years on is a dispute, not a finding. Answered: which is why the reconstruction ends at the stock records rather than at the reports. *Rational antagonist:* the manager's correct move is silence and he takes it, throughout. The pressure is entirely institutional. *Ordinary player:* "why would an insurer hide a report that helps it?" It does not help it; that is the counterintuitive fact the episode is built on and it must land in phase one. *Producer:* lightest of the nine. One location, two roles, documents only. **PASS.**

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds:* a fifteen-year-old fire ruled nobody's fault, and a second report that says where it started, which nobody filed. *Materially affected now:* a sixty-nine-year-old refused a benefit since 2011, and a retired investigator carrying a failure that was not his. *Rational resistance:* the insurer, lawfully. *Player's hands:* two reports and a stock ledger. *First choice:* publish the report or protect the source.

N2

Premise. Two deaths at the same Highcliff Heights address, eleven years apart, both certified natural by the same doctor: the owner in 2009 and her live-in companion in 2020. Neither was referred. The house passed twice, and both times to the same beneficiary, who is the doctor's brother-in-law. The doctor is not a killer and has never been paid. He is a man who certified two deaths he did not examine closely because he was asked to by family, as he has done a dozen times for people he considered kind to him.

Contested record. Two death certificates, unchallenged, which have already transferred a property twice and are directing a third transfer now.

Axes. One: misclassified · Two: **a timeline**, the certifications set against the doctor's own movements and the property record · Three: **a culprit exposed but not yet chargeable. Live consequence:** continued access or power, and institutional decision.

Named living person and mechanism. A third occupant living at the address now, eighty-one, whose care is arranged by the same beneficiary and whose will was altered four months ago. And the doctor, still practising, still certifying.

Resistance. The beneficiary, protecting a property and a pattern. The doctor, protecting a career from the discovery that his kindness was used. And a professional body whose interest is in orderly process rather than in speed. **Not a clock.**

What the player's hands reconstruct. A timeline: two certifications, the doctor's rounds on both days, the property transfers, the will alterations, the care arrangements. The conclusion is not that the doctor lied but that he was never there. The action is a referral to the coroner and to the professional body.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally approaches the doctor before the beneficiary knows. Approaching him first may bring the whole thing out in a morning and may equally cause him to close ranks and warn the family; going around him protects the third occupant and guarantees he becomes an opponent.

Access map, decisive item: the two death certificates and the property transfers. 1. *Possessed by* the registry and the land titles office. 2. *Disclosable* because both are public registers open to search. 3. *Inaccessible:* medical records, the doctor's notes, the wills before probate, and the third occupant's care file. 4. *Ally proceeds* entirely on public register searches, which is the cleanest access position in the pack. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** the registers show the pattern and not the reason, so she builds three leads on the doctor being paid. He was not. Alleging it publicly is the mistake that costs her, and the truth, that he was simply asked by people he liked, is worse and harder to prove.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events. Beneficiary arranges care and access · first death, unwitnessed, certified without close examination because a treating doctor may lawfully certify · property transfers on probate · eleven years pass · second death, same route, same doctor, and nothing in the system compares two certificates eleven years apart because nothing is built to. **Verdict: PASS.** The safeguard that fails is comparison, and comparison across a decade is the thing no institution does.

Kill brief. *Professional:* a coroner would ask what actually establishes homicide here, since two natural certifications are not evidence of anything. Answered: they are not the proof; the proof is the third will and the third occupant, and the episode must be honest that the first two may never be provable. *Rational antagonist:* patient, unhurried, does nothing until threatened, then protects the property rather than escalating. Correct behaviour throughout. *Ordinary player:* "a doctor who signs without looking" is the most believable thing in the pack. *Producer:* one location, three roles, register work. **PASS.**

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds:* two deaths at one address, eleven years apart, the same signature on both. *Materially affected now:* an eighty-one-year-old at that address, whose will changed four months ago. *Rational resistance:* the beneficiary, the doctor's career, the professional body's pace. *Player's hands:* a timeline against two public registers. *First choice:* approach the doctor first, or go around him.

N3

Premise. A woman died in a Rivermouth boarding house in 2013 and the finding was misadventure. Her toxicology samples were destroyed on schedule in 2020, correctly, because nobody had asked for them to be retained. The reason nobody asked is that the only person who wanted the case reopened was her son, who was nineteen, in care, and did not know that asking was a thing a person could do. The man who killed her still manages the boarding house. What survives is the sample **custody record**, which shows the samples were signed out for eleven days in 2014 and returned, by a laboratory officer who no longer works there and whose sign-out reason field is blank.

Contested record. Misadventure, standing since 2013, which has already closed an inquest and framed a family.

Axes. One: misclassified · Two: **the custody history of an object**, the samples' movements rather than the samples · Three: **a deliberately limited publication to prevent further harm. Live consequence:** wrongful loss of status, and continued access or power.

Named living person and mechanism. Her son, now thirty-two, who has carried misadventure to mean the thing everybody assumed it meant. And the current residents of a boarding house still managed by the same man, who selects who gets a room.

Resistance. The manager, protecting a position that gives him access. The laboratory, protecting a destruction schedule that was correctly followed and would nonetheless be catastrophic in a headline. **Not a clock.**

What the player's hands reconstruct. The custody history: who signed the samples out, when, why the reason field is blank, where they went for eleven days, and what was tested in that window that does not appear in the filed toxicology. The conclusion is that a test was run and not reported. The action is a coronial reopening on new facts, without the samples.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally names the boarding house on air. Naming it warns the current residents and empties the house, which is a real protection and also destroys the only witnesses she has, all of whom depend on him for a bed.

Access map, decisive item: the sample custody record. 1. *Possessed by* the laboratory. 2. *Disclosable* to the family of the deceased on request, as the record of handling of their relative's material, which is the son's standing and the reason he must be a participant rather than a subject. 3. *Inaccessible:* the samples themselves, destroyed; the laboratory's internal correspondence; the officer, who need not speak. 4. *Ally*

proceeds on the son's entitlement and on a retired officer's willingness. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** the custody record shows movement and not purpose, so she reads the eleven days as evidence tampering by someone protecting the manager. It is not. It is a laboratory officer running an unauthorised comparison for an unrelated case and burying it to protect himself, and that man is not a murderer, and destroying him publicly is the cost of getting it wrong.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events. She is killed in a room he controls · the scene supports misadventure and there is no reason to look further · inquest returns misadventure on the material supplied · samples retained on schedule, then destroyed on schedule in 2020 because no interested party sought retention and the son does not know he is one · the custody record survives because destruction schedules apply to material and not to the record of handling it. **Verdict: PASS.** Every institutional step is correct. The failure is that a nineteen-year-old in care did not know a question existed.

Kill brief. *Professional:* a coroner would say that without samples this is unprovable. Largely true, and the episode's resolution is a limited publication and a reopened finding rather than a prosecution, which is why axis three is what it is. *Rational antagonist:* he has done nothing for twelve years and continues to do nothing, which is correct and is the source of the dread. *Ordinary player:* "why didn't anyone ask?" is the whole episode and is answered by a nineteen-year-old in care. *Producer:* one location, three roles. **PASS.**

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds:* samples destroyed correctly, and a custody record showing eleven days nobody can explain. *Materially affected now:* a man of thirty-two carrying a word, and everybody currently holding a room from the same manager. *Rational resistance:* the manager, and a laboratory that did nothing wrong. *Player's hands:* a custody history. *First choice:* name the house, or protect the witnesses who live in it.

FAMILY THREE — OFFICIALLY SOLVED BUT CONTESTED

C1

Premise. In 2009 a man was convicted of murdering his business partner in a warehouse fire at Pier 13. The case rested on a fire investigator's testimony about pour patterns and crazed glass, both of which were treated at trial as reliable indicators of accelerant and both of which the field has since abandoned. He has served sixteen years. The fire was electrical, in a switchboard the landlord had been told about twice. The partner died because he went back in for a laptop.

Contested record. A conviction, upheld once on appeal, resting substantially on a technique the discipline no longer accepts.

Axes. One: officially solved but contested · Two: **a document set**, the trial transcript, the exhibit photographs and the maintenance correspondence · Three: **legal review or exoneration. Live consequence:** wrongful loss of liberty, and public lie blocking remedy.

Named living person and mechanism. The convicted man, sixteen years in, whose second appeal application must be lodged with fresh and compelling evidence or not at all. And the dead partner's daughter, who has believed for sixteen years that her father was murdered by his friend, and for whom being wrong is not a relief.

Resistance. The fire investigator, now senior in his field, whose reputation rests on a body of opinions built the same way. The prosecuting institution, protecting a conviction. **Not a clock.** The appeal window is the

clock and is recorded separately.

What the player's hands reconstruct. A document set: the trial transcript against the exhibit photographs, the landlord's maintenance correspondence, the switchboard's service history, and the current professional guidance that supersedes the testimony. The conclusion is that the indicators relied on do not support what they were said to support. The action is a second-appeal application.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally goes to the fire investigator before publishing. Going to him first may produce the recantation that makes the appeal, or may produce a man who spends six months defending sixteen years of opinions; publishing first guarantees the second outcome and guarantees the story.

Access map, decisive item: the trial transcript and exhibit photographs. 1. *Possessed by* the court; exhibits with the court or the police. 2. *Disclosable* because the trial was public and the transcript is obtainable; the convicted man may obtain his own case material through counsel. 3. *Inaccessible*: the investigator's working notes, the prosecution's internal assessments, and any unused material not disclosed at trial. 4. *Ally proceeds* through the public record and through counsel acting for the convicted man, never on a right of her own. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** with the transcript but not the unused material, she concludes the prosecution knew the technique was doubtful in 2009 and ran it anyway. It did not know. The discipline had not turned yet, which is worse, because it means nobody in that courtroom did anything wrong and a man still served sixteen years.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events. A switchboard the landlord was told about twice fails · the partner returns for a laptop and dies · fire investigation identifies pour patterns and crazed glass, honestly, by the standards then current · charge and trial, expert evidence unchallenged because no competing standard existed · conviction, appeal dismissed. **Verdict: PASS.** There is no bypass anywhere, because nobody bypassed anything. This is the purest institutional-failure premise in the execution: every actor performed correctly against a standard that was wrong.

Kill brief. *Professional:* an appellate lawyer would say a change in expert consensus is not automatically fresh and compelling evidence and courts resist re-litigating expert conclusions. Correct, and it is the episode's central obstacle rather than a hole in it. *Rational antagonist:* the investigator's correct move is to defend his body of work, which is what a reasonable person does and is not villainy, and it is enough. *Ordinary player:* "the science was wrong" is the most familiar true-crime shape there is, which is both its strength and its risk of feeling secondhand. *Producer:* one new location, three roles, documents only. **PASS.**

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds:* a man sixteen years into a sentence built on a technique his own accusers no longer use. *Materially affected now:* him, and a daughter for whom being wrong is not a relief. *Rational resistance:* an expert defending a career, and an institution defending a verdict. *Player's hands:* a transcript against photographs and a maintenance file. *First choice:* approach the expert, or publish.

C2

Premise. A conviction from 2014 rests on a single identification: a witness who named a man he saw from the Stonebridge Viaduct walkway, at a distance of just over two hundred metres, at nine minutes past six on a November evening. The harbour's own visibility log for that hour records fog reducing horizontal visibility below one hundred metres, which is why two ferry services were cancelled that evening and the cancellations are in a public record. Nobody at trial asked what the witness could see. The convicted woman has served eleven years. Her brother did it.

Contested record. A conviction resting on an identification that the weather record makes impossible.

Axes. One: officially solved but contested · Two: **an environmental model**, visibility rather than tide · Three: **legal review or exoneration. Live consequence:** wrongful loss of liberty, and continued access or power, because her brother is free and is now the guardian of her son.

Named living person and mechanism. The convicted woman, eleven years in. And her son, nineteen, in his uncle's care since he was eight, who has been told his whole life what his mother did.

Resistance. The brother, protecting liberty and a guardianship. The witness, elderly, who is not lying and cannot bear to be wrong. And the prosecuting institution. **Not a clock.**

What the player's hands reconstruct. An environmental model: the visibility log, the ferry cancellations, the walkway's sightline, the lamp positions, the actual distance, and what a person can resolve at that range in that condition. The conclusion is not that the witness lied but that he cannot have seen a face. The action is a second-appeal application.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally tells the son what she has before it is proven. Telling him gives her the family access she cannot otherwise get and puts a nineteen-year-old in a house with the man who did it; not telling protects him and leaves her outside every door that matters.

Access map, decisive item: the harbour visibility log for that hour. 1. *Possessed by* the harbour authority; the ferry cancellations are separately public. 2. *Disclosable* because operational visibility records supporting public service cancellations are published or obtainable, and the cancellations themselves are a public record. 3. *Inaccessible:* the witness's original statement in full, police running sheets, and unused material. 4. *Ally proceeds* on public records and, for the case material, through counsel for the convicted woman. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** with visibility but not the statement, she concludes the witness was pressured. He was not. He was asked a leading question by a tired officer and answered it honestly, and accusing him publicly of lying is the mistake that closes the one door she needed.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events. The brother kills, on the walkway approach, in fog · a witness sees a figure and later, shown a photograph, identifies a face he could not have resolved · the identification is taken in good faith and is never tested against the weather because nobody thinks to · charge and trial, the visibility record existing and unexamined in a public archive throughout · conviction. **Verdict: PASS.** The safeguard that failed is that nobody asked a question, which requires no bypass.

Kill brief. *Professional:* a defence lawyer would ask why this was not raised at trial, and the honest answer, that nobody thought of it, is both true and uncomfortable. *Rational antagonist:* the brother's correct move is to do nothing and raise the boy, and he does, which makes him the most quietly horrible antagonist in the execution. *Ordinary player:* "they didn't check the fog?" is the objection and it is also the point. *Producer:* the visibility model is the one genuinely new evidence interaction in the family, and it is a chart. **PASS.**

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds:* a face identified at two hundred metres on an evening the ferries stopped running because nobody could see. *Materially affected now:* a woman eleven years in, and a nineteen-year-old living with the man who did it. *Rational resistance:* a brother with a guardianship, a witness who cannot bear to be wrong. *Player's hands:* a visibility model against a sightline. *First choice:* tell the son, or stay outside.

C3

Premise. A 2017 conviction rests on a timeline assembled from a corner shop's till receipts, which placed the accused two streets from a killing at 7.42 p.m. The till's clock ran nine minutes fast and had done for months, which the shop's own reconciliation sheets show, because the owner corrected for it by hand every night. Nine minutes moves the accused from two streets away to inside a bus that is on a schedule. He has served eight years. The reconciliation sheets were in the shop's back room until it closed in 2022, and are now in a box at the owner's daughter's house.

Contested record. A conviction built on a timeline nobody checked against the instrument that produced it.

Axes. One: officially solved but contested · Two: **a timeline** · Three: **a partial remedy with a named cost. Live consequence:** wrongful loss of liberty, and evidence opportunity closing, because the box is in a garage that floods.

Named living person and mechanism. The convicted man, eight years in, and his mother, who has kept every receipt of her own from that night and has been told for eight years that they prove nothing.

Resistance. The shop owner's daughter, who does not want her dead father's business connected to a murder and is under no obligation to give anybody a box. The prosecuting institution. And, quietly, the original investigating officer, now retired, who assembled the timeline in good faith and would have to say so.

Not a clock. The flooding garage is the clock and is recorded separately.

What the player's hands reconstruct. A timeline: till receipts, the nightly reconciliation sheets, the bus schedule, the corrected clock offset, the original police running sheet. The conclusion is that every timestamp in the case is nine minutes wrong in the same direction. The action is a second-appeal application.

First consequential decision. Whether Ally offers the daughter anonymity in exchange for the box. Anonymity gets the box and costs her the ability to prove provenance, which an appeal will require; refusing it keeps the provenance and may lose the box to a garage that floods.

Access map, decisive item: the shop's nightly reconciliation sheets. 1. *Possessed by* the owner's daughter, privately, as inherited effects. 2. *Disclosable* entirely at her discretion. There is no entitlement of any kind, from anybody, and that is the whole access problem. 3. *Inaccessible:* the till itself, scrapped; the shop; the original exhibit receipts, held by the court. 4. *Ally proceeds* by persuading one private person, with nothing to offer but anonymity she may not be able to honour. 5. **What Ally gets wrong:** with the sheets but not the running sheet, she concludes the officer knew the clock was fast. He did not. He was never told, and the person who could have told him was the shop owner, who was never asked, and who is dead. Alleging otherwise is what nearly makes the retired officer an enemy instead of a witness.

Kill Gate Zero — first five causal events. A till clock drifts nine minutes fast and is corrected by hand nightly, which is ordinary small-business practice · a killing occurs and the accused's alibi is assembled from receipts · the timestamps are treated as authoritative because printed times generally are · trial, conviction, no challenge to the instrument · the shop closes and the reconciliation sheets pass into private hands. **Verdict: PASS.** Nothing is bypassed. A printed number was believed.

Kill brief. *Professional:* an appellate lawyer would ask whether uncorroborated private sheets can establish an instrument's error years later, and the answer is that provenance is the whole fight, which is why the first decision is about provenance. *Rational antagonist:* there is barely an antagonist, and the resistance is a reluctant daughter and an institution's inertia. **This is the weakest resistance in the execution and it is declared rather than dressed up.** *Ordinary player:* "a wrong clock" is small, and smallness is either the

charm or the failure. *Producer*: lightest of the nine after N1. **PASS**, with the resistance weakness noted for whoever takes it to Mode B.

Desk gate. *First thirty seconds*: eight years built on a printed time from a till that ran nine minutes fast, corrected by hand every night in a book nobody read. *Materially affected now*: a man eight years in, and a box in a garage that floods. *Rational resistance*: a daughter with no obligation, an institution with inertia. *Player's hands*: a timeline against a reconciliation book. *First choice*: offer anonymity for the box, or keep provenance.

EXECUTION RECORD

Field	Value
Execution ID	EX-2026-08-24-02
Mode invoked	A
Model and mode	Claude Opus 5, extended reasoning, web research available
Project-source versions	pivot brief 2026-08-23 incl. 08-24 rulings · charter 2026-08-23 · VO lock v1.1 · bible incl. §2.3.1 and §5.2 marker · roster incl. Del adds · portrait prompts · two disposition documents
Research record	Fire origin and cause · fire evidence destruction · fire investigation reliability and NFPA 921 · coronial reopening on new facts · second and subsequent criminal appeal · misapplied forensic science. Sources cited in 1.5
Seed field	Field one 24, exactly 8 per family. Field two 6, fresh family only
Rotating generation order followed	Round one fresh, never-solved, contested. Round two never-solved, contested, fresh. Round three contested, fresh, never-solved. 3, 3, 2 per family. Only the stated batch generated at each turn
Gate Zero attrition	21 of 30 seeds rejected. Grounds: occupied or retired territory 4 · Havenbay necessity 5 · antagonist rationality 4 · UNKNOWN on a premise-dependent process 3 · no reconstructive play 3 · coincidence-led 2
Desk-gate result per premise	All nine pass. Failing question for rejected seeds recorded in 1.4 for the five closest
Survivors per family	Fresh 3 (2 from field one, 1 from field two) · Never solved or misclassified 3 · Officially solved but contested 3
Candidate insufficiency	Fresh family insufficient after field one, brought to three by the permitted second field. Reported, not smoothed
Backbone desk failure	None. Both contested families supplied three from field one
Forming-record wording used	F1, F2, F3. Each stated in its sketch and recorded as a stage-of-record asymmetry
Axis values	Reported per premise. Consecutive-repeat rule applies at slate construction, not at generation
Genre-anatomy reference used	NO
Keep / do-not-keep result	Not applicable. Recorded later, when openings are blind-reviewed
Owner disposition	<i>pending</i>

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT, AND WHAT DOES NOT

Mode A ends here. No cold opens have been written, no premise has been titled, nothing has been ranked, and no recommendation is made. Those are prohibited in this mode and their absence is deliberate rather than an omission.

The next steps, in order, per the consensus protocol:

1. **Desk-gate review** of these nine by a second party.
2. **Nine openings written** for the survivors, one hundred and twenty to one hundred and sixty spoken words, each dramatising an event and making the live consequence legible. Resistance, reconstruction and the first decision stay at the desk gate and need not appear in the spoken text.
3. **Blind craft ranking** of all nine by a person who does not know the hypothesis or the family labels, marking each keep or do-not-keep as well as ranking.
4. **Retain the top two marked-keep from each family.** If a family cannot supply two marked keep, rewrite that family or record a desk failure. Do not test an unbalanced slate.
5. **The six-opening test**, read aloud, randomised, five-second silence after each, forced first, second and stop-on, then the three questions, then the backbone reveal last.

The pool for that test is the clean Mode A survivors alone. The three standing challengers of EX-2026-08-24-01 remain live slate candidates and occupied territory, and stay outside the experiment, because they were produced under an influence excluded from Mode A.